As Wolfgang Sachs argues in a brilliant essay entitled 'Liberating the world from development':

> the competitive struggle of the global middle classes for a greater share of income and power is often carried out at the expense of the fundamental rights of the poor and powerless. As governments and businesses, urban citizens and rural elites mobilise to forge ahead with development, more often than not the land, the living space and the cultural traditions of indigenous peoples, small farmers or the urban poor are put under pressure ... The shiny side of development is often accompanied by a dark side of displacement and dispossession, which is why economic growth has time and again produced impoverishment next to enrichment (Sachs 2013:25).

However much the emergence of the BRICS as new global powers after centuries of imperial subjugation and humiliation may carry with it a deeply felt sentiment of national liberation, the practices of emerging Brazilian or Indian or South African or Chinese players in the world of big mining are little distinguishable from the pillage of their global competitors linked to old imperial centres in Europe and North America.

Note

1. Private conversation with Rick Bertrand, Sudbury, June 2012.

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